

BACK INTO THE FOLD
BJP leaders from Punjab meet Congress's K.C. Venugopal, Oct. 13

The grafting of leaders at the top leads to dissatisfied cadre on the ground. For example, in Madhya Pradesh, the BJP had to deploy Union home minister Amit Shah and Union minister Bhupender Yadav to iron out differences between its old workers and ambitious supporters of Jyotiraditya Scindia, who joined the party in 2020 from the Congress along with 22 MLAs. In Karnataka, BJP leaders are struggling to retain six turncoat MLAs. After getting news of discontent in Punjab, BJP national president J.P. Nadda had recently met disgruntled leaders and instructed Punjab BJP chief Sunil Jakhar to accommodate them. So, in a sense, the exodus came as a shock.

In Punjab, as the state unit battles factionalism, poor reading of the ground situation led national leaders to encourage the induction of turncoats without appreciating their rivalry with local party leaders as well as factionalism within the Congress and the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), from where they were sourced. All this points to a communication gap between the BJP high command and the state unit. Furthermore, new inductees find it tough to adjust to the BJP's way of functioning; many join it under the impression that the move will give them protection from police and state vigilance bureau probes.

In Punjab, after they split with the SAD in 2020, the BJP has been trying to expand its influence among the rural Jat Sikh community, alongside extending its base to all 117 assembly constituencies. The success ratio has been patchy. Barring Verka, everyone in the present exodus is a Jat Sikh. That not only hurts its strategic project, but shows it up as potentially undercooked.

In early July, the BJP had appointed former Congressman Sunil Jakhar as state unit chief. He promptly dropped Verka from the list of office-bearers and appointed his rival, former IAS officer Jagmohan Singh, as the new state general secretary. Verka, upset that his views were not being considered for the forthcoming local body polls, not only exited, he also took two estranged Jakhar loyalists—Balbir Sidhu and Kangar—with him. The two were upset about Kangar being replaced as one of the five general secretaries by the much junior Parminder Brar.

AS THE PUNJAB BJP BATTLES FACTIONALISM, POOR STRATEGY HAS LED THE HIGH COMMAND TO INDUCT TURNCOATS

There is a clash of cultures too. The Punjab Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party have borrowed the SAD's practice of appointing 'halqa (constituency) in-charges' in places where the party did not win—leaders who are responsible for an assembly constituency, often wield influence in its administration and get to contest the polls from there. The BJP didn't adopt this, giving new entrants no space to grow. The BJP also inducted SAD and Congress candidates in many constituencies where they already have a party leader. This spurred more factionalism.

The vigilance bureau in Punjab is conducting probes against several Opposition leaders, including Sidhu and Kangar, while Arora is out on bail in a case relating to a land deal. The BJP has said that they have no truck with those facing corruption probes. "There was no commitment from the BJP for any protection in corruption cases," says a BJP leader in New Delhi. However, with the Congress and the ruling AAP part of the INDIA bloc, many think the three leaders, now that they are back with the Congress, may get protection.

For now, Jakhar is taking responsibility for the exodus. But by no means can he be blamed alone. In September 2022, the BJP appointed former Gujarat CM Vijay Rupani as its Punjab in-charge, meant to liaise between the state BJP and the party high command. Many in the BJP complain that he doesn't spend enough time in Punjab. Again, BJP general secretary (organisation) of Punjab, Mantri Srinivasulu, was to maintain a balance of aspiration among all the factions in the party. But local reports speak of him clashing with both former state BJP chief Ashwini Sharma and now with Jakhar. Several Punjab BJP leaders told INDIA TODAY that though the setback is temporary, course correction is needed to improve the party's prospects. "Quality of communication between the central and the state unit needs to improve," says a leader. That and a more cohesive party leadership should hold them in good stead. ■